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Chapter 15 – Teaching Language and Power

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Abstract

Language pedagogies that attend to the teaching of language and power are collectively captured through the term critical literacy. Although the field is diverse, the word 'critical' signals a stance toward deconstructing oppression and advocating for emancipation, as well as an understanding of power as discursive and material. This chapter traces developments in linguistics that attended to issues of knowledge, power, and identities within literacy education. Building on work of sociolinguists, critical linguists turned to systemic functional linguistics and critical language awareness, both of which posit that one's communicative choices and "appropriate" use are dependent on social contexts and issues of power. This understanding gave rise to genre studies, New Literacy Studies, critical applied linguistics, critical discourse analysis, and multiliteracies, all of which undergird critical literacy in its

varied approaches. The chapter outlines the recognized global “hotspots” where critical literacy education has developed and the influential scholars who have contributed to the field. After a discussion of the systems of distribution that have impacted critical literacy practices, the chapter reviews current scholarship that spans locations, disciplines, contexts, and educational levels. Finally, in a discussion of future directions in the teaching of language and power, the chapter addresses issues of equity and access and the strong local and global networks that are required to sustain teachers’ work. It also contends with the various tensions that arise as the field continues to shift and change.

Keywords

Critical Literacy; Linguistics; Critical Language Awareness; Genre Studies; New Literacy Studies

Introduction

The teaching of language and power is a recognized approach to language education in primary, secondary, and schools of teacher education. In Australia, Canada, Cyprus, and South Africa, it is included in curricular policy. Critical literacy is an umbrella term for language pedagogies that grew out of the discipline of linguistics (including critical linguistics, critical language awareness (CLA), genre theory, critical discourse analysis) and work in the field of adult literacy. This use of the word ‘critical’ signals a stance toward deconstructing oppression and advocating for emancipation. Critical literacy practices invite students to engage critically with representational systems to ask and answer the questions—Whose interests are served by the way in which language is used? Who benefits? Who is disadvantaged?—so

that out of this understanding, possibilities for change can emerge. Critical literacy is underpinned by a strong equity and social justice agenda.

Practicing critical literacy depends on understanding that language is not a neutral tool for communication but is everywhere implicated in the ways in which we read and write the world, the ways in which knowledge is produced and legitimated, and the ways in which a human subject is constructed as a complex set of identities based on, amongst other things, race, class, gender, ability, age, nationality, sexual orientation. Critical literacy practitioners engage with the dialectic of domination and emancipation, which requires an understanding of power as discursive and material.

Early Developments

The questioning of knowledge, power, and identities within the context of literacy education can be traced across time to Greek philosophers, movements of intellectual enlightenment, and revolutionary struggles across time and place. In more recent history, we can look to examples of how literacy campaigns were used to inspire proficiency with the written word and awaken a revolutionary consciousness.

Dialogic teaching, text /social analysis, and social action are all hallmark features of critical literacy education, which relies on critical social theory and linguistics for its roots.

Hymes (1972) brought about a fundamental change in language education, arguing that in addition to acquiring linguistic competence, children also had to acquire communicative competence. He established that language use is a fundamentally social activity and that communicative competence requires an ability to use language appropriately given the sociolinguistic context. Such competence includes knowing which language variety and register is most suited to a social

occasion; for multilingual children it requires strategically selecting features of their language repertoires, and the complicated social understandings necessary for translanguaging. His work made space for the social in language education, and paved the way for contemporary scholarship on language ideology (e.g. McKinney, 2016).

At the same time, Labov was conducting important research on language varieties. His work demonstrated conclusively that the so-called non-standard varieties of English are fully systematic, rule-governed languages as capable of abstract logical reasoning as so-called standard varieties (Labov, 1972). What sets these varieties apart is their social status, not any inherent linguistic superiority or inferiority. Bernstein's (1971) work, although widely misinterpreted at the time, drew attention to the cultural capital that was necessary for success in schools. Part of that cultural capital included having access to both the linguistic and communicative competencies valued uncritically by the school.

The communicative approach was the pedagogic realization of these theories in second language education. Emphasis was placed on effective communication and, for the first time, fluency and appropriateness were seen to be as important as accuracy, which had dominated earlier structural approaches to language teaching. Clark, Fairclough, Ivanic and Martin-Jones (1987), in a paper that gave birth to critical language awareness (CLA), provided the first challenge to approaches to language education that did not question existing social structures. 'Appropriateness', the concept at the heart of the social in language education, came under their critical scrutiny because what is appropriate is decided by social norms, which, in contexts of power (institutions, prestigious job interviews, media), are inevitably the naturalized cultural practices of social élites. This was related to the pioneering work on critical

linguistics developed by Fowler, Kress, Hodge and Trew (1979). *Critical Language Awareness*, edited by Fairclough (1992), was the first edited collection of CLA as practice. It raised and began to answer some of the key questions on the teaching of language and power. How are students to be given access to the discourses of power in their educational institutions so that these are not simply reproduced? How much language competence do students need before CLA can be taught in second or foreign language classes? When does CLA become emancipatory?

These developments would not have been possible without systemic functional linguistics (SFL), developed by Halliday (1985). SFL established a foundation for understanding language as a 'social semiotic' and for mapping the relationship between language, text, and context. This grammar, which is 'a theory of meaning as choice' (Halliday, 1985, p. xiv), has provided the tools for critical discourse analysis, genre theory, and multimodal analysis. It creates the opportunity to include the power-meaning potential when teaching linguistic structures. Students learning grammar can simultaneously learn about the relationship between modality and authority, or about the connection between 'us' and 'them' pronouns and othering discourses, and they can learn to recognize who is a 'doer' and who is a 'done-to' when they are taught transitivity and voice. This critical approach to linguistic structures has also been effectively applied to the teaching of critical writing as can be seen in the work of Kamler (2001).

Once Halliday moved to Australia, the University of Sydney became the center for SFL. Using SFL, genre theorists described the generic and linguistic features of six dominant factual genres—reports, recounts, procedures, explanations, expositions and discussions—to be able to teach them to students. Genre pedagogy

was specifically designed to give marginalized students in Australia access to dominant forms of language, and the Disadvantaged Schools Project developed both classroom materials and an explicit pedagogy. Likewise, Delpit (1995), working with African American students in the USA, recognized the importance of both access, critique, and reconstruction of dominant genres. Primary English Teachers' Association Australia (PETAA) publications have made both Hallidayan grammar and genre theory widely accessible to teachers (<http://www.petaa.edu.au/>).

The work of educational linguists such as Courtney Cazden, James Gee, Nancy Hornberger, David Corson and Bonny Norton on discourse analysis, language and diversity, and language and identity forged links between North American versions of critical literacy and developments elsewhere. Freire's (1970) work was extended by ethnographic research on literacy, which generated the New Literacy Studies (Gee, 1990; Street, 1984). Some of the classroom work it gave rise to focuses on situated literacy practices in contexts of power (e.g., Pahl and Rowsell, 2005). Likewise, Pennycook's (2001) critical applied linguistics has provided a theoretical base for considering the political economy of languages.

Changes in the communication landscape prompted theorists to rethink literacy in a digital age. Kress and van Leeuwen (2001) focused attention on multimodal forms of communication, which increasingly use forms of semiosis (image, gesture, sound) in addition to or other than language. Under the leadership of Cope and Kalantzis (2000), the multiliteracies project has explicated the literacies needed for changes in both semiosis and technologies and made links across specialist interests such as: genre theory; discourse theory; language learning in multilingual

and indigenous communities; social and citizenship education; feminist linguistics; and learning in a neoliberal work order.

Research on diversity, difference, and othering, often from a feminist, neo-Marxist, critical race theory, post-colonial, or gay and lesbian perspective, has included careful work on language and its power to construct and delimit the ways in which we think the other and ourselves. Although this work has played a formative role in the development of critical literacy, a full review of this literature is outside the scope of this chapter (for more on this, see Rowland and King, this volume).

Major Contributions

Published accounts of critical literacy practice can be found in all continents except Antarctica, representing at least forty-five countries. However, recognized “hotspots” for critical literacy education have developed. It is within these areas that well-formed traditions have emerged.

Freire's (1970) work in Brazil shows how, in the process of critically learning to read both the word and the world, adult literacy learners regain a sense of themselves as agents who can act to transform social situations. Freire continues to be the main influence on critical literacy in North America, as seen, for example, in the work of Antiona Darder, Carol Edelsky, Donaldo Macedo, Peter McLaren, Brian Morgan, Ernest Morrell, Ira Shor, Roger Simon and Mariana Souto-Manning. Founded by Miles Horton and influenced by the work of Freire, Highlander Center in New Market, Tennessee (USA) continues to be an active center for popular education (<http://highlandercenter.org/>).

Australia was at the forefront of developing theorized classroom practice in the area of critical literacy. The theoretical contributions of Allan and Carmen Luke,

Carolyn Baker and Peter Freebody, Bronwyn Mellor and Annette Patterson, Pam Gilbert, Bill Green, Barbara Comber, Barbara Kamler and the New Zealander Colin Lankshear laid the foundations for classroom practice. Freebody and Luke's (1990) four resources model is an approach that attends to both the cognitive and social dimensions of literacy learning. The model includes four social practices that students take up (code breakers, text participants, text analysts/critics and text users) as they become critically literate. This model was incorporated into Queensland's *New Basics* curriculum. Comber and colleagues (2015) have for two decades theorized, supported, and showcased the work of classroom teachers who have made a difference to the lives of marginal students. Bronwyn Mellor, with colleagues in Western Australia, led the early development of classroom materials through the founding of Chalkface Press (<http://www.chalkface.net.au/>).

In South Africa, Janks (2010) developed a critical literacy framework in response to the struggles against apartheid. She proposed four concepts central to understanding language and power: *domination*, *access*, *diversity*, and *design*. *Domination* refers to the idea that discourse plays an important role in the maintenance of power relationships. *Access* focuses on providing students with the tools of dominant discourses, without devaluing primary discourses. *Diversity* embraces engagement with various literacies and a range of modalities, which facilitates experimentation with social identities. *Design*—or the productive and creative potential of power—is conceptualized as a way to challenge and change existing discourses. Janks points out that these concepts are interdependent. The *CLA Series* (Janks, 1993; Janks, Dixon, Ferreira, Granville and Newfield, 2014) situates itself across the first language/second language divide and is written in English that is

accessible to students who speak African languages. This series is the only set of classroom materials specifically designed to translate CLA into classroom practice. The apartheid context in which they were written gives a political edge to these workbooks, which make it clear that language is both a site and a stake in struggles for a more humane and just world.

In the United States, Jerome Harste and colleagues at Indiana University cultivated university-school partnerships with critical literacy as a central part of curriculum at both levels. Their approach to critical literacy has been synthesized into a model often used by practitioners (Lewison, Leland, and Harste, 2008). The model includes instructional practices including *disrupting the common place*, *interrogating multiple viewpoints*, *considering the sociopolitical*, and *taking action for social justice*. The goal of such instruction is to promote meaningful inquiry through student-teacher partnerships, while giving voice to marginalized groups of people. The influence of this tradition can be seen through the critical literacy work of Deborah Rowe (young children's authoring practices), Gerald Campano (immigrant literacies), Kathy Short (inquiry and social justice in children's literature), Tasha Tropp Laman (teacher education) and Katie van Sluys (multilingual classrooms) and Lee Heffernan (writing), all prolific and influential scholar-practitioners in this area. Indeed, Vivian Vasquez's (2004) book, *Negotiating Critical Literacies with Young Children*, featuring Vasquez's work as a teacher-researcher, is now in its tenth year anniversary edition.

Systems of distribution play a major role in the impact of critical literacy practices. Foundational and emerging critical literacy work has been published in anthologies, monographs, and handbooks. Thus, publishing companies and editors

have influenced the growth of critical collections. Through Senior Editor Naomi Silverman's stewardship, Routledge has a well-developed list of critical literacy titles, including work by JuliAna Avila, Richard Beach, Barbara Comber, Hilary Janks, Cynthia Lewis, Ernest Morrell, Kate Pahl, Jessica Pandya, Jennifer Rowsell, Rebecca Rogers, Vivian Vasquez, and Melissa Mosley Wetzels (see, for example, <https://www.routledge.com/Language-Culture-and-Teaching-Series/book-series/LEALCTS>) Peter Lang has a sizable collection of critical media literacy texts edited by Colin Lankshear. Teachers College Press has a series focused on critical issues in educational leadership, multiculturalism, and teaching for social justice. This includes work by Alma Flora Ada, Deborah Appleman, Catherine Compton-Lily, Kris Gutiérrez, Valerie Kinloch, Candace Kuby, Michele Lazar, Carmen Mercado, Jamie Myers and many others (see <http://www.teacherscollegepress.com/browse.html>). Stenhouse, under the editorial guidance of Philippa Stratton, offers accessible and critically oriented accounts of language and literacy practice geared for teachers. Peer-reviewed journals have also contributed to the circulation of research-based accounts. Major sources of critical literacy scholarship appear in general education journals (e.g., *Teachers College Record*), curriculum journals (e.g., *Curriculum Inquiry*; *Journal of Curriculum Studies*), critical education journals (e.g., *Critical Studies in Education*; *Journal of Critical Pedagogy*; *Critical Inquiry into Language Studies*; *Pedagogies*), multilingual/multicultural journals (e.g., *International Journal of Multilingual Studies*; *Journal of Second Language Writing*; *TESOL Quarterly*), discourse analytic journals (e.g., *Critical Discourse Studies*; *Discourse*; *Linguistics and Education*) and journals devoted to literacy studies (e.g., *Journal of Literacy Research*; *Language Arts*; *Literacy*). Some journals such as *The Reading Teacher*,

Journal of Adolescent and Adult Literacy, *Language Arts*, *Literacy* and *Australian Journal of Language and Literacy* have wide rates of circulation to teachers and have a more direct influence on classroom practice. For example, under the editorship of Luke and Elkins, *Journal for Adolescent and Adult Literacy* (1997 to 2002) made critical approaches more available to teachers in North America. There have also been a number of themed issues devoted to critical literacy scholarship: *Primary Voices* (2000); *Language Arts* (2002); *New England Reading Association Journal* (2007); *Voices from the Middle* (2009); *English Education* (2009); *Theory into Practice* (2011); and *English Teaching: Practice and Critique* (2012). This list is not exhaustive because of the geopolitics of database vendors and critical scholarship being conducted in places such as Southeast Asia with more covert names.

Early efforts by publishing companies to develop curriculum materials included The Chalkface Press workbooks (<http://www.chalkface.net.au/>), which introduced students to post-structuralist theory for textual deconstruction, focusing on literary texts and used innovative activities that taught an understanding of reading positions. The U.S. edition of these workbooks, published in 2002 by the National Council for Teachers of English, increased their influence. Janks developed the Critical Language Awareness Series that has been updated and is now called *Doing Critical Literacy* (Janks et al., 2014). The Rethinking Schools project has produced cross-curricular guides on gender and sexuality, globalization, the environmental crisis, war, and media (<http://www.rethinkingschools.org/>). Rethinking Schools is part of the Network of Teacher Activist Groups (TAG), a coalition of grassroots teacher organizations that provide curricular materials and support teachers as agents of change at both local and national levels (<http://www.teacheractivistgroups.org>).

Work in Progress

The field of critical literacy is diverse, spanning locations, disciplines, contexts, and educational levels. Across approaches different emphases are placed on deconstructing texts or creating alternatives and the role of social action. Some approaches have a greater socio-cognitive focus (e.g., Dozier, Johnston, & Rogers, 2006). These efforts are often reported as individual published accounts but, when taken together, create a cumulative effect in particular sociopolitical areas of interest (Rogers & O'Daniels, 2015).

Issues of diversity and discrimination related to race, ethnicity, religion, language, and culture often arise within the context of language and literacy teaching. There is a great deal of work in this area supported theoretically by the scholarship of Bonny Norton, Ryuko Kubota and Allan Luke. Alford and Jetnikoff (2011), working in an Australian context, describe exemplar cases of secondary teachers who effectively use critical literacy practices with their English as an additional language/dialect students. Likewise, Sepulveda (2011) demonstrated how young Latino men narrated their experiences as transmigrants through poetry and autobiographical writing.

There are also good examples of teachers taking on issues of social class, gentrification, and neoliberalism. Barbara Comber and colleagues out of Australia have worked extensively with students in a low socio-economic area in South Australia that has undergone massive urban renewal. Through various collaborative teacher-research projects, they have documented how students respond to the gentrification efforts and how they take up various literacy practices, both in and out of school (Comber, 2015). Analysis and critical readings of social class and

consumerism have been conducted with learners across the lifespan, from educators (e.g., Albers and Harste, 2013) to kindergartners (e.g., Labadie, Pole and Rogers, 2013). Jones and Vagle's (2013) scholarship focuses on social class and poverty with the goal of building toward a theory of social class-sensitive pedagogy. Poverty is one of the pressing issues that teacher-scholars must continue to address.

Critical literacy has been applied across the school curriculum to the analysis of school history textbooks in Austria, to the exploration of the construction of gendered discourses in school geography, to citizenship education. For example, McClune, Alexander and Jarman (2012), working in the United Kingdom, studied the intersection of critical literacy with science media. Practitioners have combined critical literacy practices with environmental education and ecology (Clayton, 2015). Other cross-disciplinary initiatives include the incorporation of CLA into a business communications course at a Singaporean university (Weninger and Kan, 2013) and the use of mathematics as a tool for social critique (Wayne, 2009).

How criticality is taught and learned by novice and experienced educators is essential to the deep integration of critical literacy in schools. Allen and Alexander (2013) illustrate how teachers use a human rights framework to engage students in critical inquiry into pressing social issues such as immigration rights, religious tolerance, racial equality, countering the effects of poverty, and respect for people with disabilities. Dozier, Johnston, and Rogers (2006) and Rogers and Mosley Wetzel (2014) demonstrate the integration of critical and accelerative literacy with novice and more experienced literacy teachers in literacy clinics. Vasquez, Tate, and Harste (2013) delineate the conditions that lead teachers to accept or resist the critical teaching of language and power.

Current work in critical genre studies shows that serious attention to genre is not antithetical to the aims of critical literacy, provided that genres are not reified and taught as static conventions reduced, in some of the more rigid genre positions, to formulae operating according to fixed rules. Studies in this area suggest that students can both access dominant genres and reconstruct them; what students need is an understanding of the historical and social determinants of these forms, an ability to adapt these forms as the conditions change, and efforts to change these conditions (e.g. O'Hallaron, Palincsar, & Schleppegrell, 2015).

There is also a coalescing body of work in performative and dramatized forms of critical literacy practice. For a decade or more, Carol Rozansky has worked in Augusto Boal's tradition of Image Theatre, inviting youth and educators to use theatre to deconstruct and reconstruct power relations. (e.g. Rozansky and Aagesen, 2010). Spoken word poetry is another performance art that has captured the attention of critical literacy practitioners (e.g., Scarbrough and Allen, 2014). Patricia Enciso and Brian Edmiston are well known in the U.S. and U.K. for work in drama and storytelling. Embodied literacies give attention to how students use their bodies, clothing, gestures and affective responses to perform critical literacy (e.g., Johnson, 2011; Lewis and Tierney, 2013).

Critical literacy is beginning to contend with the criticism that it is fundamentally a rationalist activity that does not address the non-rational investments that readers bring with them to texts and tasks. Pioneer work in this area included Norton's (2000) theory of 'investment' in relation to language acquisition and identity, Janks' (2002) work on identification and Lillis' (2001) work on writing and desire. Benesch (2012) offers new insights on the emotional labor that critical

pedagogues perform, including emotion management and the explicit teaching of emotions.

Around the globe, critical media literacy has grown in prominence. Some projects focus on deconstructing media and popular culture texts whereas others have a greater focus on designing new practices. For example, Ernest Morrell and colleagues (2013) focused on critical media pedagogies and how they can be harnessed for deep learning, achievement, and building democratic communities. Merchant contributes scholarship focused on interaction, collaboration, and learning in online environments, including virtual 3-D worlds and social media (Burnett & Merchant, 2011). Ávila and Pandya (2013) offer a rich account of critical digital literacies, engaging with issues such as ethics, the market economy, and collective intelligence.

Future Directions: Difficulties and Promises

The teaching of language and power has deepened and solidified in many areas of the world. We have many descriptive accounts coalescing into knowledge domains, developed theoretical frameworks, and policy efforts. Critical literacy is being carried out with very young children and adults, in classrooms and communities. The issue of 'readiness' that haunted early critical literacy has been overturned. We know from a decade of research that an understanding of textual positioning requires an understanding of the subtlety and nuances of words; however, there are texts of different degrees of linguistic complexity, and any text that is suitable for the level of learners to read is suitable for critical analysis at that level. The principles of critical literacy can be translated across time and contexts; yet, the vast majority of children, youth, and families do not have deep and prolonged exposure to the social analysis,

cultural critique, and relationships necessary for creating a more humane world. This is an issue of equity and access.

To truly radicalize practice, both in classrooms and communities, critical literacy cannot rely on published accounts in journals and books. Vasquez created *Critical Literacy in Practice Podcast* (CLIP) (<http://www.clippodcast.com/>) as a way to distribute examples of teaching and learning. *Global Conversations in Literacy Research* (GCLR), conceived of by Margaret Albers, is a series of interactive open access web seminars features timely critical literacy research and shows the potential of creating a global network devoted to critical literacy practices (<https://globalconversationsinliteracy.wordpress.com>).

Critical literacy is a continual process of challenging and establishing standpoints, intervening and creating more favorable social conditions (in discussions, in schools, in policies). Program-level efforts are needed to infuse critical literacy across disciplinary areas, courses in a program, and grade levels. Luke, Woods, and Weir's (2013) book offers pioneering work in this kind of integrated and longitudinal effort. To spread and consolidate the material effects of this curricular work, both local and global networks are needed to support and sustain teachers' work. Grassroots groups such as Educators for Social Justice provide local accounts of how this is possible (Rogers, Mosley, Kramer & LSJTRG, 2009).

Critical scholar-practitioners must also contend with a number of tensions that have arisen. What are the material consequences of critical literacy, for example? This is a question of how changing practices result in changes in material conditions within schools (e.g., achievement records, placement decisions) and more broadly (e.g., meaningful relationships, engagement in the community, life satisfaction, and even

happiness). There are many accounts of children and youth gaining access to dominant texts, critiquing and reconstructing them, *and* achieving academic excellence. These accounts can be levers for advocating for deep changes in curriculum policies. However, we have fewer accounts of what difference critical literacy makes over the long haul. We might also approach the critical project from a different angle and try to understand how people across communities accomplish important goals using language (broadly construed) and power.

Emancipation involves both discursive and material conditions. Critical literacy has to take seriously the ways in which meaning systems are implicated in reproducing domination and it has to provide access to dominant languages, literacies and genres, while simultaneously using diversity as a productive resource for redesigning social futures and for changing the horizons of possibility. This includes both changing dominant discourses as well as changing which discourses are dominant. Most important is the recognition that critical literacy is not static. In this realm, post-humanist theory is again shifting the ground.

In her book, *Meeting the Universe Halfway: Quantum Physics and the Entanglement of Matter and Meaning*, Karen Barad (2007) argues that human subjects, like other phenomena, are part of the material world and that knowing comes from material intra-actions with the world. Every intra-action reconfigures the world and the possibilities for being as a part of it. Knowing, acting and being are 'entangled' material practices that affect matter in and across time and space – timespacematterings. In addition to having responsibilities to the societies we inhabit, we also have responsibilities to the world in all its materiality and all its diversity.

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